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PhD Admissions Committee
School of Architecture and Interior Design
College of Design, Architecture, Art, and Planning (DAAP)
University of Cincinnati, Cincinnati, Ohio, USA

Dear Members of the Admissions Committee,

Ask a child what they want to become, and the answer often changes from week to week; mine never did. As a primary-school pupil, I always gave the same reply: an architect. While other children spent hours on the playing field, I built little houses and other small objects from clay, the same material that, with bamboo, formed the homes around me. At that age I only knew that the person who makes houses is called an architect. Later, in secondary school, I joined the science stream, and physics, chemistry, and mathematics filled my days, but I kept drawing and painting in watercolour.

History was never one of my school subjects. It came to me through my younger sister, a humanities student, who liked to read her lessons aloud. From the next room, I heard how Pompeii was buried under volcanic ash in a single day, and how the Indus Valley city of Mohenjo-daro lay forgotten under the earth for thousands of years. I was amazed that buildings could outlive the people who made them and still tell their story.

Today, that early curiosity has grown into a clear research direction, and it brings me to the PhD in Architecture at the University of Cincinnati. The discipline fascinates me at every scale, from a single building to an entire city. I am especially interested in how the places we live in carry their history, and how they can be adapted, rather than erased, as societies, economies, and climates change. For me, architecture, heritage, community, and sustainability belong together: reusing what already exists saves resources, keeps a community's identity alive, and serves people today. I have explored these ideas from two directions: my architectural training in Bangladesh, where heritage sites face rapid urbanisation and climate stress, and a Master's in Germany, where I studied how European cities protect, reuse, and live with their past.

My early interests took academic shape during my five-year Bachelor of Architecture at Khulna University. Studying architectural theory and history, from Greek and Roman temples to Gothic cathedrals and Modernism, taught me that no building stands alone. In my second year, Renzo Piano's Jean-Marie Tjibaou Cultural Centre in Nouméa, New Caledonia, became my greatest inspiration. Its curved timber shells, drawn from traditional Kanak huts and shaped to catch the wind, showed me that a contemporary building can carry the memory of a culture and its vernacular way of building without simply copying it. It reminded me of the clay and bamboo houses of my childhood.

In my fourth year, I took on my first conservation project: a design studio on Barobazar, a historic area in south-west Bangladesh with Sultanate-era mosques and ancient ponds. It taught me that historic places survive best when local people benefit from them, and that protecting them means balancing the interests of the community, the government, and the local economy. My Bachelor's thesis widened the scale to a whole city, asking how Mymensingh could grow sustainably without losing its heritage. I learned that planning often treats historic buildings as obstacles to growth, but when they are woven into everyday city life, through new public uses and connected open spaces, they can strengthen a city's identity instead.

My professional experience has also shaped my thinking. During three years in architectural practice in Chattogram and Dhaka, I learned how regulations, budgets, and clients decide the fate of existing buildings. Documenting historic buildings on site taught me to read them closely: measuring walls, cracks, and changing materials showed me how much a building's condition reveals about its needs. Learning how rising water and

storms threaten historic sites on Bangladesh's coast made me realise that saving old buildings often means adapting them, not only protecting them. These experiences made me want to study such questions more deeply.

To broaden my perspective, I moved to Germany for a Master's in Architectural and Cultural Heritage at Anhalt University of Applied Sciences, Dessau. There I saw how Europe keeps its past alive through planning, reuse, and tourism, and how even modern buildings, like the Bauhaus, are worth preserving. The programme combined conservation theory with hands-on skills such as digital documentation and half-timber construction. My thesis examined how Berlin reused and reinterpreted its war-damaged infrastructure, and what those choices meant for the city's identity. Through it, I learned how such structures can be technically repaired, how policy decides what is rebuilt, and why these decisions carry a social responsibility towards the people who live there. The writing sample included with this application is an excerpt from my Master's thesis.

UC's PhD in Architecture grew out of a long tradition of history, theory, and criticism connected to practice, which matches how I want to study existing buildings: as ideas and as real places. Because DAAP brings architecture, planning, design, and art together in one college, with a history of community-engaged urban studios, I could connect building-scale work with planning and with the people it affects. Cincinnati itself is an ideal setting: Over-the-Rhine, with one of the largest collections of nineteenth-century Italianate buildings in the United States, shows both the promise of reuse and the risk of displacing long-time residents. Studying it would let me test what I learned in Bangladesh and Germany in a third, very different context.

I am particularly drawn to the work of Professor Rebecca Williamson and Professor Aarati Kanekar. Professor Williamson's research on architecture and urbanism, from political design in eighteenth-century Italy to the hidden infrastructure beneath city streets, connects with my interest in how power, time, and use reshape buildings, and with my work on Berlin. Her essay "Thinking Through Building," which argues that architectural ideas take shape through the act of building, over time and with many people, also reflects how I understand adaptive reuse. Professor Kanekar's research on how space carries meaning, and her current work on space in traditional Indian representations, relate closely to my experience in South Asia, where historic places are still part of everyday life.

In my doctoral research, I hope to explore how communities and urban areas can become more sustainable while caring for the places they already have. I am interested in how cities that have faced war, decline, or climate stress decide what to keep, what to change, and who benefits, with preservation and adaptive reuse as two of several possible approaches. I see this as a starting point rather than a fixed topic, and I look forward to shaping it with my advisor and the faculty at DAAP.

After the PhD, I hope to teach and research in architecture and to help shape policies for sustainable, historically aware cities, particularly in South Asia, where historic buildings are disappearing quickly and research in this field is still growing.

Thank you for considering my application. I would welcome the opportunity to contribute to the research community at DAAP, and I would be glad to discuss my research interests further.

Sincerely,

Priyati Golder